International Association of Societies of Design Research Congress 2025
DESIGN NEXT
Taipei, Taiwan
2-4 December 2025

The Old Hong Kong Style: Preserving the Past in Specialty Coffee Shops

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The promotion of specialty coffee and the opening of coffee shops have surged in Hong Kong in recent years, establishing the city as a leading destination for specialty coffee. A previous study revealed an intentional effort to preserve what we refer to as an 'Old Hong Kong style' in the design of these shops. To better understand the motivations behind this design choice, this study investigates the intentions of those involved in shaping these spaces. We conducted semi-structured interviews with 11 representatives from modern specialty coffee shops identified as exhibiting a deliberate 'Old Hong Kong' aesthetic. The interview participants included store owners, staff, and designers who were directly involved in the design and decision-making processes during the shops' construction or renovation. The results reveal four categories of intentions: (1) a desire to utilise the spatial and aesthetic potential of older sites, (2) a wish to attract consumers through the storytelling embedded in reused elements, (3) an ambition to share and promote Hong Kong's cultural heritage, and (4) a pragmatic effort to save costs and resources. While environmental sustainability was seldom articulated as a primary driver, many of the projects may nonetheless be understood as embodying sustainable design practices, as they extend the lifespan of materials and reduce the need for new production. The findings illuminate how spatial design can become a tool not only for branding or establishing ambiance but also for cultural preservation in a rapidly transforming urban landscape.

Keywords: Hong Kong; coffee shop design; culture and heritage; sustainable design

1 Introduction

Carefully branded and design-conscious, specialty coffee shops have been studied globally as spaces for consumption, connection, and community (Ferreira & Ferreira, 2021; Lannigan, 2020; Tucker, 2017). These so-called 'third wave' coffee shops strongly emphasise coffee quality and sourcing as well as diverse methods of preparation (Ferreira, 2015). They have assumed an increasingly visible presence in the global market. In recent years, this culture has flourished in Hong Kong, positioning

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the city as a prominent hub for specialty coffee (Barber & Münster, 2023). These cafés tend to be located in older neighbourhoods, where rapid urban regeneration attracts new flows of people and strong contrasts between old and new building styles (Siqi & Magramo, 2021). In this context, opening coffee shops in old buildings has led to a new type of interior design that reestablishes a local style using fragments of past materials (Münster et al., 2024).

This paper is part of a larger study intended to illuminate the style and culture of this specific group of coffee shops. As the first phase of data collection, the broader study included historical research and desk research on more than 700 coffee shops across Hong Kong. We also conducted place-based observational studies in over 100 shops, gathering photos, making field notes, and holding informal interviews. An analysis of this initial dataset revealed that certain traditional Hong Kong-style interior elements were frequently reused during the remodelling process. This suggests an intentional effort to preserve what we refer to as the "Old Hong Kong style." By this, we mean a design aesthetic defined by elements commonly associated with Hong Kong's classic urban and interior landscape—such as metal shutters, mosaic tiles, vintage furniture, and neon signs (Hong Kong Memory, 2012).

This style manifested in several ways: first, through the direct reuse of architectural and decorative elements; second, through a distinctive aesthetic created by the recontextualisation of traditional features; and third, through the incorporation of newly fabricated elements inspired by the Old Hong Kong style. This paper seeks to identify the motivations behind these design choices. It presents semi-structured interviews with representatives from contemporary specialty coffee shops, which had been identified by the researchers as places incorporating an 'Old Hong Kong' aesthetic. The findings reveal four key intentions behind the adoption of the Old Hong Kong style. Each of these categories is presented and discussed in the paper. Together, they offer a portrait of an international city undergoing rapid cultural and urban transformation. This study thus characterises a population that, in response to the imminent loss of the shops, interiors, buildings, and cultural elements that have shaped its identity, has turned to spatial design as a means of preserving – or at least prolonging – the narrative of a distinctive local style.

2 Background

Buildings account for approximately 40% of global energy consumption and CO_2 emissions, and they are the largest consumers of raw materials worldwide (World Economic Forum, 2022). This presents the construction industry with a significant challenge due to this sector's high demand for materials and energy, necessitating substantial reductions in carbon emissions and the implementation of impact-reducing strategies (World Economic Forum, 2022). In response to this challenge, climate researchers strongly advocate for avoiding new construction and instead aligning human needs with the existing building stock. This can be achieved by utilising vacant and shared spaces, renovating existing structures, or – albeit only when necessary – extending them (Kuittinen, 2023). Similarly, researchers in the field of store design are increasingly engaging with the sustainability-related aspects of retail interiors (Alexander et al., 2025).

With a population of 7.4 million and a land area of just 1,114 km², Hong Kong is one of the world's most densely populated cities (World Data Info, 2024). Buildable land is limited. Thus, to create more space for the city's growing population, older structures are frequently demolished, making way for new and taller developments (Chan & Lee, 2008). Rental spaces in these new commercial or mixed-

use buildings tend to be expensive, prompting many small coffee shops to establish themselves in older buildings.

This use of older buildings heavily influences the overall atmosphere of these cafés. Atmospheric qualities evoke emotional responses and influence consumer behaviour, and they can themselves be experienced as a form of consumption (Kotler, 1973). Combining old and new atmospheric components can yield unique environments shaped by the interplay of different design eras. One such example was explored in a recent study of coffee shops in Copenhagen, which demonstrated how vacant industrial buildings can, with minimal renovation, be transformed into appealing destinations. These spaces offer not only sustainable solutions but also aesthetic virtues, including spaciousness, narrative presence, inviting surroundings, and distinctive atmospheres fashioned from the fusion of old and new elements (Münster, 2024). Thus, beyond promoting sustainability through the occupation of existing structures, this strategy of merging the old and the new can give rise to unique atmospheric characteristics.

3 Method

3.1 Research approach

This study is part of a broader research project focused on adaptive reuse in coffee shop design. Our interest in understanding the intentions behind the use of Old Hong Kong-style elements in coffee shops emerged from a key finding in the broader study. In that study, we conducted observational analyses of over 100 coffee shops in Hong Kong and explored the atmospheric benefits of opening cafés in buildings not originally intended for this purpose. It examined how novel atmospheres are created through the combination of old and new building components. The analysis revealed that design elements are often deliberately reused in the remodelling process, indicating an intention to preserve what is considered a distinct Old Hong Kong style.

This style is expressed through the direct reuse of buildings and architectural components; it involves the recontextualisation and refabrication of Old Hong Kong-style elements (Münster et al., 2024). To better understand the motivations underlying this design tendency, we launched the present study. Given the study's exploratory nature, we adopted a qualitative approach (Crick, 2021; Gioia, 2013) to investigate the reasoning behind the use of Old Hong Kong-style elements in contemporary specialty coffee shops in Hong Kong. We considered factors ranging from the choice of the cafe's location, neighbourhood characteristics, architectural characteristics, spatial design elements, furniture, signage, the choice of cups, and other decorative components.

3.2 Case selection

From the more than 100 cafés visited as part of the broader study, we identified what we refer to as Old Hong Kong–style elements in 34 establishments. These cases were examined in greater depth, and we selected 10 cafés where the presence of such elements was particularly pronounced. In these cases, all researchers involved in the analysis agreed that the Old Hong Kong‑style features were clearly recognizable and that their inclusion in the shop interiors appeared deliberate.

At nine of these shops, we were granted permission to conduct interviews. These cases are presented in Table 1.

3.3 Semistructured interviews

To gain insight into the intentions behind design decisions made during the restoration or implementation phases of launching these shops, semistructured interviews were conducted with owners, designers, and store managers who were directly involved and thus familiar with the design rationale. This approach allowed participants to articulate their thoughts, actions, and intentions in their own words. In some cases, the interviewees also included staff such as baristas, who were particularly helpful when they referred to knowledge gained through their work at the café.

Store representatives were recruited by searching online for the names of shop owners and by visiting coffee shops in person to ask for the owners. Either the owner or colleagues involved in the remodelling process were then invited to participate in an interview. In total, 11 interview participants took part in the study between 2023 and 2025. In a few cases, interviews were conducted spontaneously if the respondent was available at the time, but they were typically scheduled in advance. The interviews took place in the coffee shops, were audio-recorded, and were then transcribed. When conducted in Cantonese, the transcripts were translated into English. The participants were first invited to share the history of the café and then asked specific questions about the restoration phase and the decisions made during that process. The researcher also pointed out specific elements in the store that appeared to have been preserved from former occupants and asked follow-up questions about them. Additionally, the researcher enquired about the overall atmosphere that the management aimed to create in the café. These interviews varied in duration; the shortest was 10 minutes, and the longest was 80 minutes.

	Abbreviated name of shop	**Role of interviewee**
Interview 1	SA	Owner
Interview 2	HW	Owner
Interview 3	MW	Owner
Interview 4	GO	Owner
Interview 5	GO	Barista
Interview 6	NH	Manger
Interview 7	SH	Owner
Interview 8	TO	Owner
Interview 9	TO	Manger
Interview 10	TW	Owner
Interview 11	CW	Designer
Total		**11 interviews**

Table 1. A list of the examined shops and the store representatives who sat for interviews.

4 Analysis

The interview transcripts were analysed using Atlas.ti. Three researchers who were familiar with the study and hail from diverse cultural backgrounds – a local Hongkonger, a recent resident, and an international observer – analysed and interpreted the data. These researchers thoroughly reviewed the data, applied relevant terms and codes, and eventually developed a comprehensive set of categories for the interview material (Gioia et al., 2013). The categories were then examined for similarities and differences, and the data were organised based on these patterns. When the authors did not agree on terms or connections, they revisited and discussed the data until a consensus was reached. This iterative process involved multiple rounds of adjustments, ultimately yielding the data structure presented in Table 2.

Intentions	**Aggregate themes of intentions**
• Preservation of site-specific characteristics • Uniqueness rooted in local materials and contexts • Location choice based on neighbourhood characteristics • Preference for street-facing shops integrated with neighbourhood • Preservation of original architectural features • Personal connection to and observation of neighbourhood changes	**Intent to utilise space-based potential/Intent to preserve**
• Using storytelling to appeal to customers • Selective display of aesthetically appealing heritage items • Evoking nostalgia and shared memories to attract customers • Blending cultural elements to spark customer engagement and appreciation	**Intent to attract consumers**
• Desire to give back to the community • Desire to tell Hong Kong's story to both locals and visitors • Desire to preserve and share objects and their associated stories • Collecting and curating items to connect with and inform the neighbourhood • Desire to share knowledge of specific neighbourhoods or traditions	**Intent to share Hong Kong's culture/heritage**
• Wish to save money by reusing elements or keeping existing ones • Wish to retain existing elements if they make sense in the new context • Choice of location in an old building due to lower rent	**Intent to save resources**

Table 2. Data structure: The intentions reported by store representatives are shown on the left, and the aggregate themes are presented on the right.

5 Presentation of Findings

In this section, the reported intentions behind using Old Hong Kong-style elements in contemporary specialty coffee shops are presented and discussed. The section is organised according to the four aggregate themes presented in Table 2. While there is some overlap between themes, we aimed to present each one separately whenever feasible.

5.1 Intent to utilise space-based potential/Intent to preserve

This category encompasses efforts to implement what we call 'place-based potential'. This concept refers to the idea that the distinctive characteristics of a certain geographic area – such as its demographics, natural resources, cultural heritage, economic conditions, and social networks – can be harnessed to support development and address local challenges. Unlike a 'one size fits all' approach, this perspective highlights the importance of tailoring strategies to the contextual specificity of each place (Barca, 2009). This concept has evolved in response to contributions from various disciplines, including geography, urban planning, regional development, and the social sciences, rather than being the work of a single scholar.

We found that the term 'place-based potential' evokes several of the expressions shared by our informants. For example, one store owner remarked, 'We don't plan to open another [Name of café] in a different location because we are site-specific and aim to authentically preserve every element and maintain its original look and feel in the context of that district' (Figure 1a). In another owner's words, 'When we start choosing the location, we are focusing on residential areas, like To Kwa Wan or Cheung Sha Wan or some redeveloped residential area, because of its unique context between new and old' (Figure 1b).



Figure 1. 1a. Modern specialty coffee shop inside a cha chaan teng (old tea restaurant). 1b. New café in an old neighbourhood. 1c. Metal doors reused as decorations in the shop.

Some respondents also referred to singularities rooted in local materials, such as gates and tiles specific to the local retail context: 'This is space-specific, as the shop fits into this existing envelope with this existing material, and it can only exist here in Hong Kong'. Another compared the space-based qualities of their site to a shop in a mall:

> At this moment, we are not considering opening one of our shops in a shopping mall. Because the shop in the street is more integrated with the streetscape, people almost discover places as they walk. I feel this is the main characteristic of Hong Kong. Here, we have the streetscape.

One representative mentioned that they have actively preserved building elements because they tell a story about the place:

> This building has been here for, like, over 60 years and general is, like, this metalware hardware shop. And they have this kind of, like, a steel channel that move loading stuffs or equipment around. So, at the beginning, when we found this shop, we feel it's really interesting. So, we try to keep this kind of urban fabric, this urban context. When we designed the shop, we kept these steel structures. (Figure 1c)

Meanwhile, others told us about the development of the surrounding neighbourhood and explained how they were sorry to see old shops disappear: 'This is an old district, and old shops are continually closed and undergo redevelopment. This also happened in Sham Shu Po, where I was born. I witnessed the changes in the neighbourhood'. Such expressions suggest a form of nostalgia, which may be one reason for an increased interest in preserving existing elements (Huppatz, 2009).

5.2 Intent to attract consumers

In addition to the desire to preserve place-based elements in their cafés, some shop owners also stated that the atmospheres created by these local elements can attract guests and boost sales. One café owner, who reused interior elements of an old pharmacy in his café, said,

> I definitely see the value [of reusing Old-Hong-Kong-style elements in the café]. Because otherwise the project would not be very interesting. And from the marketing point of view, I think we've been open for six years now, and we still get new customers every day almost. And the reason is because there's a story about it. It's not just an empty shop. So, I would totally do it again. (Figure 2a).



Figure 2. 2a. Pharmacy interior, Tai Wo Tang. 2b. Pharmacy details, e.g. certificates, Tai Wo Tang. 2c. Coffee cups in coffee shop interior.

He described how both interior and decorative elements can contribute to building an atmosphere. However, the management had to carefully select the items that made sense in the new context – keeping in mind what the new users of the space would appreciate:

> There were over hundreds of items [when they took over the place]. And we had to choose which ones are aesthetically pleasing to the customer, which ones are clean, which ones are safe. So, there was a big knife that was originally used to cut medicine, but obviously, it's very dangerous to have this in a café, right? So, we couldn't put those items in. We also chose those certificates. So, all these are kind of, like, special things that we wanted to reuse. (Figure 2b)

Some also described how preserving certain elements can help reconvey shared memories and nostalgia, which can be appealing to customers:

> I'm very practical. From my point of view, instead of focusing on preserving the structure or the object itself, I would put more emphasis on the memories, the identity, and the nostalgic feeling. We could maintain the whole story, yet we need to adapt it to the new style.

One mentioned an episode in which he recalled customers speaking with him about the old cups in the shop. He realised that such elements can spark customer engagement and appreciation:

> I bought some Chinese-style cups to practice latte art with the theme of East meets West. So, I made the coffee and gave it to my foreign customer to taste it. One of the customers discussed the cups instead, and that became the idea to start of [Name of café]. (Figure 2c).

5.3 Intent to share Hong Kong's culture/heritage

The third category reflects a desire to not only preserve old elements but also use them to share Hong Kong's cultural heritage with others. While showing us around a small exhibition they had opened in the space next to the coffee shop to showcase a collection of Old-Hong-Kong-style cups, furniture, and other decoration items, a store owner said, 'We are still collecting [Old-Hong-Kong-style cups and other decorations], organising the information, and exploring appropriate ways to tell the stories' (Figure 3a). He explained that over many years, he had collected beautiful Chinese cups and later decided to use them in the coffee shop so that others could enjoy them as well (Figure 3b). Since then, they have started displaying the portion of the collection not in use in a curated exhibition in a neighbouring space, where anyone interested is welcome to drop in and view the items.

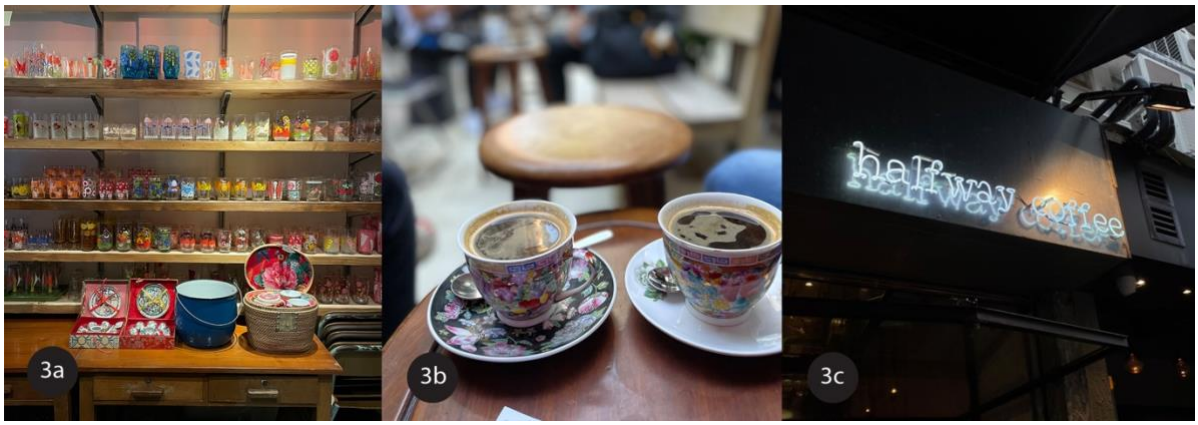


Figure 3. 3a. Exhibition of cups in space next to the coffee shop. 3b. Coffee served in old porcelain cups with colourful Chinese decorations. 3c. A neon sign at a coffee shop.

He mentioned buying the cups at street markets in the neighbourhood and expressed a desire to give something back to the community while sharing stories with visitors from outside: 'I'm very lucky to be born in Hong Kong. I understand the culture and community very well', he said. The same respondent pointed out that this also applies to the designer he works with: 'If I worked with a foreigner, he may not understand or be able to present the accent in the café'. In saying this, he emphasised the importance of promoting a deeper understanding of the culture and design elements associated with it. The designer explained that they not only reused old elements but also considered the city's traditions when choosing materials for the new additions. For example, he said, 'The owner wanted to use neon [for the sign in the shop] because it's something he felt is very Hong Kong. Like from the time when Hong Kong was really well known and vibrant' (Figure 3c) – referring here to Hong Kong's tradition of neon signs and their gradual disappearance from the cityscape (Kwok, 2020).

Another store owner described their coffee shop as being located in a restored *cha chaan teng* (old tea restaurant) (Figure 4a-e). 'We aim to offer an authentic experience of cha chaan teng culture and preserve all original elements,' she continued:

> We intend to build a bond with the community and preserve and promote Hong Kong culture in a broader spectrum. In my opinion, preservation is not simply about keeping old things; it should also address today's needs and provide value to society.



Figure 4. Cha Chaan Teng style order sheet (4a), clock (4b), and façade design (4c). Specialty coffee shop with a cha chaan teng-style layout and furniture setting (4d). A poster in the façade of the coffee shop promoting a forum on cha chaan teng culture (4e).

She explained that, in addition to designing the coffee shop in the style of a classic cha chaan teng – thereby allowing guests to experience a traditional café interior – they also host exhibitions by local artists in the café and organise guided tours to old shops in the neighbourhood, which guests might not otherwise discover (Figure 4e).

5.4 Intent to save resources (conscientiousness about economy/environment)

The desire to design in an environmentally sustainable way – with the intention of preserving buildings and their elements, in accordance with Kuttinen's (2024) recommendations for sustainability – was largely absent from the interviews conducted. However, some did reflect on this aspect when asked directly. One store owner said,

> I think, at the beginning point, it's a kind of way of saving. We want to keep it as honest as possible. So, of course, honesty, yeah. So, I think from the starting point to make it simple, because we want to keep the original elements, that is already a sustainable way.

Although most did not mention sustainability as a motivation, several informants pointed out that reuse conserves resources: 'Because of the budget concerns, we preserved some elements. They were beautiful, so from a design perspective, we also wanted to keep those elements'. In this way, reuse has served as a sustainable solution both economically and environmentally, as it reduces the need for new production and material consumption. Others also mentioned being located in old buildings as an economically sustainable choice:

> The reason for choosing this location [in an old building] is because it is in a redeveloped district with a newly built residential cluster and commercial buildings nearby. The spending power is relatively high, and due to the pandemic, rental costs [in the old building] are relatively low.

Thus, although the reuse of old cups, furniture, building elements, decorative elements, and architectural elements did not primarily stem from a desire to create an environmentally friendly solution, there are indications that this practice contributes to the longevity of both buildings and materials. This aligns with the recommendations of climate researchers as well as research on design and the circular economy (Bocken et al., 2016; Kuittinen, 2023).

6 Suggestions for Future Studies

This study examines store owners' and designers' intentions in reusing what we call Old Hong Kong-style interiors, architecture, and other elements in modern coffee shops. However, it has not addressed the concrete implementation of these elements. Future studies could examine the practical challenges of reusing elements in coffee shops. Some store owners mentioned wanting to reuse more elements than was possible, pointing to challenges stemming from the condition of the building or inventory: 'When we first started, we thought that we would only need to do minimal repairs. However, due to the poor condition underneath, we had to rebuild some fixtures, such as the ceiling and kitchen workstation'.

In a similar context, we heard the following: 'The canopy that we use now is the original one. But recently, we plan to change the automatic system, which may require to refabricate the new canopy. Somehow, I hope can keep its as original as possible'.

Aspects of renovation involving the combination of old elements with new ones in a traditional style were also mentioned: ‘We renewed the wallpaper with the same pattern’, and ‘We refurbished the booth seats with new leather covers. And additionally, we brought chairs from a second-hand store. They were from a closed Chinese restaurant, and the clock was also from a second-hand store’. An overview of such experiences could benefit craftspeople, project managers, and store owners in future projects.

Further research could also investigate the relationship between building regulations and the preservation of cultural heritage elements. Several store owners reported that regulations limited their ability to reuse certain features they wished to retain – for example, having to reduce the size of a façade cupboard due to licensing restrictions, or removing parts of a structure to obtain a food licence, which required hiring a registered structural engineer to ensure safety compliance. Deeper insights into these topics could provide valuable guidance for craftspeople, policymakers, project managers, and store owners involved in future heritage-sensitive projects.

Finally, further studies could explore how the presence of a new business in older buildings may contribute to the latter’s preservation. A store owner mentioned that after they started renting the space, Hong Kong’s Antiquities and Monuments Office became involved, likely because the café helped raise awareness about the building. As a result, the shophouse is now listed and receives funding for revitalisation and maintenance. This was also observed in a study of cafés in Denmark, where the demolition of an old building was postponed after local café guests became aware of it and succeeded in halting the process (Münster, 2024).

Conclusion

This study suggests that the intentions of store owners and designers to preserve and reuse Old Hong Kong-style elements in contemporary specialty coffee shops can be grouped into four main categories: (1) an intent to utilise the spatial and aesthetic potential of older sites, (2) a wish to attract consumers through the stories conveyed by these elements, (3) an ambition to share and promote Hong Kong’s cultural heritage, and (4) a pragmatic approach to saving costs and resources. While sustainability was not commonly mentioned as a direct motivation in the interviews, these projects can nonetheless be considered environmentally sustainable, as reuse helps extend the life of materials and reduces the need for new production.

Together, these findings paint a portrait of an international city undergoing rapid cultural and urban transformation. They portray a population that, faced with the imminent loss of the shops, buildings, interiors, and cultural elements that have shaped their identity, is turning to spatial design as a way to preserve, or at least prolong, the narrative of a distinctive local style. This study offers a brief yet evocative snapshot – through both images and text – of a design aesthetic that is gradually disappearing and unintentionally promotes sustainable practices in interior design.

Acknowledgements

The work described in this paper was supported by a grant from the Research Grants Council of the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region (project no GRF/PolyU P0047073). We would like to express our sincere gratitude to all participants for taking part in the interviews and for sharing their valuable experiences and insights.

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